

Materia Medica III-Herbs that Transform Phlegm

Overview

Phlegm-transforming herbs resolve phlegm (tan), redirect rebellious Lung and Stomach qi, relieve cough and wheezing, and soften nodules or masses. Phlegm is both a pathological product and a pathogenic factor, frequently complicating chronic disease.

These herbs are subdivided clinically into: - Cold phlegm vs. hot phlegm - Wind-phlegm obstructing the channels - Phlegm nodules and masses

General Characteristics

Attribute	Description
Taste	Bitter, acrid
Temperature	Warm (cold phlegm) or cold (hot phlegm)
Channels	Lung, Spleen (primary)
Core Actions	Transform phlegm; stop cough; redirect qi

GLOBAL FUNCTION

Used when phlegm presents as:

- cough/wheeze
 - nausea from phlegm obstruction
 - nodules, goiter, scrofula
 - wind-phlegm stroke patterns
 - phlegm-heat agitation
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GLOBAL CAUTIONS

- Avoid in Yin deficiency dryness (warm drying herbs)
 - Toxic herbs must be processed (Ban Xia, Tian Nan Xing)
 - Use cold phlegm herbs cautiously in cold-deficiency patients
 - Do not use during the early stages of measles or rashes.
 - Stimulating phlegm herbs may worsen bleeding (e.g., hemoptysis).
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Phlegm-Transforming Herbs – Quick Reference Table

Herb	Nature	Channels	Core Exam Keywords
Ban Xia	Warm, toxic	LU, SP, ST	Dries damp; transforms phlegm; stops vomiting
Tian Nan Xing	Warm, toxic	LU, SP, LV	Dries damp; dispels wind-phlegm
Bai Jie Zi	Warm	LU	Warms Lung; dispels cold phlegm; opens channels
Zao Jiao Ci	Warm	LV, ST, LU	
Xuan Fu Hua	Slightly warm	LU, ST	Redirects qi downward; transforms phlegm
Bai Qian	Slightly warm	LU	Disperses wind-heat
Qian Hu	Slightly Cold	LU	Disperses wind-cold
Zhe Bei Mu	Cold	LU, HT	Clears heat; transforms phlegm; nodules
Chuan Bei Mu	Cold	LU, HT	Moistens Lung; chronic dry cough
Gua Lou (Pi/Ren/Shi)	Cold	LU, ST, LI	Clears heat; transforms phlegm; chest Bi
Hai Zao	Cold	KD, LV, ST	Softens hardness and masses promotes urination
Kun Bu	Cold	KD, LV, ST	Relieves irritability and stops vomiting
Zhu Ru	Slightly cold	LU, ST	Clears heat; stops vomiting; irritability
Jie Geng	Neutral	LU	Guides to Lung; expels phlegm
Pang Da Hai	Cold	LU, LI	Restores voice; clears the Intestines and unblocks the bowels

I. Warm Herbs that Dry Damp & Transform Cold Phlegm

Ban Xia 半夏

Scientific name: *Rhizoma Pinelliae*

Nature/Flavor: Acrid, warm, toxic

Channels: LU, SP, ST

Primary actions:

- Dries damp; transforms phlegm
- Redirects rebellious qi downward
- Stops vomiting
- Dissipates nodules

Top indications:

- Phlegm-damp cough with copious sputum
- Nausea/vomiting from phlegm obstruction
- Chest fullness, Globus hystericus
- Phlegm nodules

Dosage:

- 5–10 g (processed only)
- Must be processed (ginger + alumen)
- Forms:
 - Qing Ban Xia → phlegm-damp cough
 - Fa Ban Xia → wind-phlegm
 - Jiang Ban Xia → nausea/vomiting

Contraindications:

- Toxic unprocessed
- Avoid:
 - Yin deficiency dry cough
 - Heat sore throat
 - Bleeding disorders
 - Hot phlegm
- Incompatible with Wu Tou
- Overdose → neuro-oral toxicity, respiratory depression

Exam pearl:

Essential herb for phlegm and is the **yao yao** for phlegm of all types.

- Treats both:
 - phlegm-damp cough
 - phlegm-induced nausea/vomiting
- Dries from **source + branch**

Tian Nan Xing 天南星

Scientific name: *Rhizoma Arisaematis*

Nature/Flavor: Bitter, acrid, warm, toxic

Channels: LU, SP, LV

Primary actions:

- Dries damp; transforms phlegm
- Dispels wind-phlegm
- Relieves spasms

Top indications:

- Stubborn phlegm with chest oppression
- Wind-phlegm:
 - stroke
 - facial paralysis
 - seizures/convulsions
- Dizziness with phlegm obstruction

Dosage:

- 5–10 g decoction
- Dan Nan Xing: 2–5 g

Processing

- Must be pre-processed (ginger)
- Raw form toxic

Contraindications:

- Toxic
- Avoid:
 - Yin deficiency cough
 - Liver wind from heat/blood deficiency
 - Pregnancy
- Overdose toxicity severe

Exam pearl:

- “Stubborn phlegm herb”
 - Best for:
 - wind-phlegm
 - stroke patterns
 - convulsions
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Bai Jie Zi 白芥子

Scientific name: *Semen Sinapis Albae*

Nature/Flavor: Acrid, warm

Channels: LU

Primary actions:

- Warms Lung; transforms cold phlegm
- Opens channels; dissipates nodules

Top indications:

- Cold-phlegm Lung cough with clear sputum
- Chest oppression, dyspnea
- Phlegm-cold joint pain/nodules

Dosage:

- 3–10 g
- Topical vinegar paste (≤1 hr)

Processing:

- Vinegar topical application

Contraindications:

- chronic Lung deficiency cough
- yin-def heat
- Stomach fire

Exam pearl:

- Cold-phlegm Lung
- Opens channels for phlegm-cold pain

Zao Jiao Ci 皂角刺

Scientific name: *Spina Gleditsiae*

Nature/Flavor: Acrid, warm

Channels: LV, LU, ST

Primary actions:

- Expels phlegm
- Drains pus, reduces swelling
- Expels wind, kills parasites

Top indications:

- Lung abscess, suppurative lesions
- Phlegm nodules and swellings

- Carbuncles, toxic accumulations
- Specific for tinea and leprosy

Dosage:

- 3-9 g

Contraindications:

- Contraindicated with open sores and during pregnancy

Exam pearl:

- Expels pus
- Phlegm nodules

II. Herbs that Redirect Qi & Stop Cough

Jie Geng 桔梗

Scientific name: *Radix Platycodonis*

Nature/Flavor: Bitter, acrid, neutral

Channels: Lung

Primary actions:

- Disseminates Lung qi
- Expels phlegm
- Benefits throat
- Guides herbs upward

Top indications:

- Cough with sputum (wind-cold or wind-heat)
- Sore throat, hoarseness
- Lung abscess/pus discharge
- Upper-jiao phlegm disorders

Dosage:

- 3–10 g

Contraindications:

- Use caution:
 - Yin deficiency cough
 - Blood-streaked sputum

Exam pearl:

- Guides herbs upward
- Lung disorders
- Pus discharge

Xuan Fu Hua 旋复花

Scientific name: *Flos Inulae*

Nature/Flavor: Bitter, acrid, slightly warm

Channels: LU, ST

Primary actions:

- Redirects qi downward
- Transforms phlegm
- Stops vomiting

Top indications:

- Rebellious Lung qi cough with phlegm
- Nausea/vomiting from phlegm-fluid, hiccup
- Wheezing with fluid congestion

Dosage:

- 3–10 g

Processing:

- Wrap in cloth before decoction
- Honey-fried → moistens Lung

Contraindications:

- Not listed

Exam pearl:

- Direction: downward
- Lung + Stomach qi rebellion
- Fluid congestion + phlegm

Bai Qian 白前

Scientific name: *Radix Cynanchi Stauntonii*

Nature/Flavor: Acrid, sweet, slightly warm

Channels: LU

Primary actions:

- Redirects qi downward
- Expels phlegm

Top indications:

- Excess cough with copious sputum
- Cold-phlegm or hot-phlegm cough
- Dyspnea from Lung phlegm

Dosage:

- 3–10 g

Processing:

- Honey-fried → moistening

Contraindications:

- Not listed

Exam pearl:

- Redirects Lung qi downward
- Excess cough

Qian Hu 前胡

Scientific name: *Radix Peucedani*

Nature/Flavor: Bitter, acrid, slightly cold

Channels: LU

Primary actions:

- Redirects qi downward
- Expels phlegm
- Disperses wind-heat

Top indications:

- Wind-heat cough with sputum
- Thick sputum obstructing Lung
- Fever + cough + sore throat

Dosage:

- 6–10 g

Contraindications:

- Not listed

Exam pearl:

- Descends Lung qi
- Releases wind-heat

III. Cold Herbs that Clear Phlegm-Heat

Zhe Bei Mu 浙贝母

Scientific name: *Bulbus Fritillariae Thunbergii*

Nature/Flavor: Bitter, cold

Channels: Lung, Heart

Primary actions:

- Clears Lung heat
- Transforms phlegm
- Dissipates nodules

Top indications:

- Phlegm-heat cough
- Thick yellow sputum
- Early-stage Lung heat cough
- Nodules, goiter, breast abscess

Dosage:

- 4.5-9g

Contraindications:

- None noted

Exam pearl:

Zhe Bei Mu = **stronger heat clearing**

Chuan Bei Mu 川贝母

Scientific name: *Bulbus Fritillariae Cirrhosae*

Nature/Flavor: Bitter, cold

Channels: Lung, Heart

Primary actions:

- Moistens Lung
- Stops chronic cough
- Transforms phlegm

Top indications:

- Chronic dry cough
- Lung yin deficiency cough
- Scanty sputum ± blood
- Nodules (deficiency patterns)

Dosage:

- 3-9g

Contraindications:

- Unsuitable for use with cold-phlegm or damp-phlegm

Exam pearl:

Chuan Bei Mu for **deficiency + dryness**

Zhu Ru 竹茹

Scientific name: *Caulis Bambusae in Taeniam*

Nature/Flavor: Sweet, slightly cold

Channels: Lung, Stomach

Primary actions:

- Clears heat; transforms phlegm
- Stops vomiting
- Relieves irritability

Top indications:

- Phlegm-heat cough with irritability
- Nausea/vomiting from Stomach heat
- Gallbladder heat with phlegm disturbing Shen

Dosage:

- 4.5-9g

Contraindications:

- None noted

Exam pearl:

- Phlegm-heat with nausea = think Zhu Ru

IV. Gua Lou Group

Gua Lou Shi 瓜蒌实

Scientific name: *Fructus Trichosanthis*

Nature/Flavor: Sweet, cold

Channels: Large Intestine, Lung, Stomach

Primary actions:

- Clears heat; transforms phlegm
- Expands chest
- Moistens intestines

Top indications:

- Lung heat cough with thick sputum
- Chest congestion
- Constipation from Lung/LI heat
- Breast abscess

Dosage:

- Shi: 9-21 g

Contraindications:

- Contraindicated for use with deficiency-type diarrhea, weakness of the SP/ST.

Exam pearl:

- Shi → both chest Bi and intestines

Gua Lou Pi 瓜蒌皮

Scientific name: *Pericarpium Trichosanthis*

Nature/Flavor: Sweet, cold

Channels: Lungs, Stomach, Large Intestine

Primary actions:

- Clears Lung heat
- Expands chest
- Regulates qi

Top indications:

- Chest Bi with phlegm-heat
- Lung heat cough
- Qi stagnation in the chest

Dosage:

- Pi: 6–12 g

Contraindications:

- Same contraindications as Gua Lou Shi

Exam pearl:

- Pi → chest Bi

Gua Lou Ren 瓜蒌仁

Scientific name: *Semen Trichosanthis*

Nature/Flavor: Sweet, cold

Channels: Lungs, Stomach, Large Intestine

Primary actions:

- Moistens Lung
- Lubricates intestines

Top indications:

- Dry cough with difficult sputum
- Constipation from dryness
- Lung dryness + phlegm

Dosage:

- Ren: 9–15 g

Contraindications:

- Contraindicated for use with a weak, deficient Spleen plus nausea or loose stools

Exam pearl:

- Ren → intestines

V. Herbs that Soften Hardness & Dissipate Nodules

Hai Zao 海藻

Scientific name: *Sargassum*

Nature/Flavor: salty, cold

Channels: Kidney, Liver, Stomach

Primary actions:

- Dissolves phlegm
- Softens hardness

Top indications:

- Goiter
- Scrofula
- Phlegm nodules
- Edema adjunct

Dosage:

- 10–15 g

Contraindications:

- Incompatible with Gan Cao
- Use caution:
 - Spleen deficiency

Exam pearl:

- Softens hardness
 - Goiter/scrofula
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Kun Bu 昆布

Scientific name: *Thallus Eckloniae*

Nature/Flavor: salty, cold

Channels: Kidney, Liver, Stomach

Primary actions:

- Dissolves phlegm
- Softens nodules

Top indications:

- Goiter
- Neck nodules
- Chest obstruction from phlegm
- Edema adjunct

Dosage:

- 10–15 g

Contraindications:

- Not listed

Exam pearl:

- Nearly identical to Hai Zao
 - Goiter herb
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VI. Specialty Phlegm Herb

Pang Da Hai 胖大海

Scientific name: *Semen Sterculiae Lychnophorae*

Nature/Flavor: sweet, cold

Channels: Lung, Large Intestine

Primary actions:

- Clears Lung heat
- Benefits throat
- Moistens intestines

Top indications:

- Sore throat from Lung heat
- Hoarseness/voice loss
- Phlegm-heat cough
- Constipation from heat

Dosage:

- 3–5 pieces
- Tea use

Contraindications:

- Not listed

Exam pearl:

- Sore throat + constipation
- Voice herb

Master Exam Differentiation

Ban Xia vs Tian Nan Xing

- nausea/phlegm vs wind-phlegm

Zhe Bei Mu vs Chuan Bei Mu

- excess heat vs deficiency dryness

Gua Lou Pi vs Ren

- chest vs intestines

Hai Zao vs Kun Bu

- nearly interchangeable

High-Yield Comparisons

- **Ban Xia vs. Tian Nan Xing:** General phlegm vs. wind-phlegm
 - **Dan Nan Xing:** Phlegm + heat
 - **Zhe vs. Chuan Bei Mu:** Excess heat vs. deficiency dryness
 - **Gua Lou Pi vs. Ren:** Chest Bi vs. constipation
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Transform Phlegm Patterns

Toxic herbs

- Ban Xia
- Tian Nan Xing

Directional herbs

- Jie Geng → upward
- Xuan Fu Hua → downward
- Bai Qian / Qian Hu → downward

Nausea + phlegm herbs

- Ban Xia
- Zhu Ru
- Xuan Fu Hua

Nodules / goiter

- Hai Zao
 - Kun Bu
 - Bei Mu
 - Gua Lou
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